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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Kash Patel was paid by Russian filmmaker

FBI nominee got \$25,000 from Kremlin-aligned firm, documents show

This article is by Greg Miller, Jon Swaine, Catherine Belton, Mark Berman and Derek Hawkins

Kash Patel, President Donald Trump's nominee to be FBI director, was paid \$25,000 last year by a film company owned by a Russian national who also holds U.S. citizenship and has produced programs promoting "deep state" conspiracy theories and anti-Western views advanced by the Kremlin, according to a financial disclosure form Patel submitted as part of his nomination process and other documents.

Documents obtained by The Washington Post show that Patel received the money from Global Tree Pictures, a Los Angeles-based company run by Igor Lopatonok, a filmmaker whose previous projects include a pro-Russian influence campaign that received money from a fund created by Russian President Vladimir Putin.

The payment to Patel came as he participated in a documentary that Lopatonok produced depicting Patel and other veterans of the first Trump administration as victims of a conspiracy that "destroyed the lives of those who stood by Donald Trump in an attempt to remove the democratically elected president from office."

The six-part series, "All the President's Men: The Conspiracy Against Trump," aired in November on right-wing broadcaster Tucker Carlson's online network. SEE PATEL ON A10

Trump's Gaza vision leads to a Saudi shift

Path to normalizing ties with Israel is now more complicated, analysts say

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE AND SHIRA RUBIN

DOHA, QATAR — President Donald Trump's proposal to displace all Palestinians from Gaza has complicated his efforts to secure the normalization of ties between Saudi Arabia and Israel, according to Middle East analysts, but it is too early to conclude that his idea will do lasting damage to the administration's ties with the wealthy Arab kingdom.

In the hours following Trump's comments Tuesday, official Saudi reaction was swift and unequivocal, calling for an independent Palestinian state in territory including the Gaza Strip and saying that the kingdom "will not establish diplomatic relations with Israel without that." The statement, released just after 4 a.m. local time, took a firmer line than some Saudi comments in the past suggesting relations could be possible if a "pathway" to Palestinian statehood was set.

The speed of the official Saudi SEE ISRAEL ON A10



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI/GETTY IMAGES

A worker removes lettering at the Washington headquarters of the U.S. Agency for International Development on Friday. The Trump administration has targeted U.S. foreign aid programs and USAID workers as part of its effort to reshape the federal government.

Inside the skating world, as joy turned to tragedy

A heartbreaking week revealed the nature of their sport to a generation of figure skaters

BY ROBERT SAMUELS

WICHITA — The most disorienting week in the history of American figure skating started with a familiar mix of promise and nostalgia. Blocks away from the ice rink where some of the nation's best athletes leaped, twirled and left the crowd gasping, a group of the sport's old guard convened in a hotel ball-

room on Jan. 25 for the induction ceremony for the U.S. Figure Skating Hall of Fame.

This was not a fancy affair — skewers and dessert bites at buffet tables, small plates, and a 10 p.m. start time to accommodate the national championships nearby. Tina Noyes, one of the four honorees, was nervous anyway. She shuffled in the front row wearing a black dress

with sequins, going over a speech she drafted 15 times, hoping she would not break down describing the most heartbreaking moment of her life.

"These people didn't need me to stand up there and act like a blubbing fool," Noyes, 76, reflected. "I grew up in Boston — very private."

Noyes had rarely talked

about what happened in 1961, when a plane carrying the country's figure skating team crashed on its way to the world championships in Prague. Thirty-four people associated with skating died. About half of them were fellow members of the Skating Club of Boston — her mentors and role models, the people she looked up to most.

SEE SKATING ON A6

In Idaho, a preview of vaccine-skeptical America

BY LAUREN WEBER

CALDWELL, IDAHO — The doctor beamed onto a health clinic video screen in October to convince the regional health board to ban public clinics in southwest Idaho from giving the coronavirus vaccine to the district's 335,000 residents.

Ryan Cole, a pathologist who touted his expertise in immunolo-

gy and virology, called the vaccines "experimental gene therapy" and "all risk, zero benefit," falsely describing the shots that helped the country recover from a pandemic that has killed more than 1.2 million Americans.

"We shouldn't give untested products to the citizens of Idaho," said Cole, accusing Pfizer of contaminating its vaccine with "a

known carcinogen." The federal government and medical experts say that the vaccines have gone through rigorous studies and that there is no evidence the shots cause cancer.

What Cole did not reveal during the meeting: The Washington state medical board had restricted his medical license the previous January after determining he had

made "numerous demonstrably false" statements about the coronavirus vaccine, among other pandemic-related topics, according to disciplinary documents.

The board restricted Cole from practicing primary care medicine and prescribing medications in Washington amid concerns he would "use his professional posi-

SEE IDAHO ON A5



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

Another ally threatened

President Donald Trump meets with Japanese Prime Minister Shigeru Ishiba on Friday in the Oval Office. The meeting ended with a tariff warning; praise from the Japanese side eased tensions. **Story, A9**

U.K. orders Apple to let it spy on encrypted data

Secret edict requires blanket access to users' backups in cloud storage

BY JOSEPH MENN

Security officials in the United Kingdom have demanded that Apple create a back door allowing them to retrieve all the content any Apple user worldwide has uploaded to the cloud, people familiar with the matter told The Washington Post.

The British government's undisclosed order, issued last month, requires blanket capability to view fully encrypted material, not merely assistance in cracking a specific account, and has no known precedent in major democracies. Its application would mark a significant defeat for tech

companies in their decades-long battle to avoid being wielded as government tools against their users, the people said, speaking under the condition of anonymity to discuss legally and politically sensitive issues.

Rather than break the security promises it made to its users everywhere, Apple is likely to stop offering encrypted storage in the U.K., the people said. Yet that concession would not fulfill the U.K. demand for backdoor access to the service in other countries, including the United States.

The office of the Home Secretary has served Apple with a document called a technical capability notice, ordering it to provide access under the sweeping U.K. Investigatory Powers Act of 2016, which authorizes law enforcement to compel assistance from companies when needed to collect evidence, the people said.

SEE APPLE ON A12

IN THE NEWS

Slower but solid The economy picked up 143,000 jobs in January, short of forecasts, and the jobless rate fell to 4 percent. **A16**

Hitting the brakes The Transportation Department ordered a halt to a \$5 billion program to build chargers for electric vehicles on highways nationwide. **A12**

THE NATION
Rescue crews have not found a missing plane in Alaska. **A3**
President Donald Trump said he plans to fire some Kennedy Center board members and appoint himself chair. **A4**

THE WORLD
As Ukraine struggles to replenish its ranks, recruitment centers have come under attack. **A8**
A small plane in Brazil crashed into busy traffic, killing two and engulfing a bus in flames. **A9**

THE ECONOMY
For most victims of the L.A. fires, insurance policy payouts will be insufficient to cover the cost of rebuilding. **A11**
New tariffs and restrictions on Chinese imports are already hurting businesses making everything from plush toys to fast fashion. **A16**

THE REGION
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A mixed bag of light wintry weather is in the forecast Saturday, with a larger winter storm looming Tuesday. **B2**

STYLE
Officials at the National Endowment for the Arts nixed a grant program for "underserved communities." **C1**

SPORTS
Tom Brady, after a rocky first season in the booth, is back at the Super Bowl. And this time, he's not the favorite. **D1**

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